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Playing with Erlang Zotonic Modules

In continuation of earlier articles on Erlang Zotonic, let's now go through the stages of adding a chat module to the blog site that was created last month.

We begin by going a step beyond what was accomplished last month. Note that when you set up a running site in Zotonic, it is time to expand the site by using modules. One of the challenges is to see if you can make all the changes without needing to restart Zotonic.

As an example, let us select the chat module and look at adding it to the blog site.

Download the source from <http://code.google.com/p/zchat/>.

Installation and getting started

Start the Zotonic server and keep it running in a terminal window:

```
$ cd zotonic
$ ./start.sh
```

Download the zip file of the source from <http://code.google.com/p/zchat/source/browse/> and install it in the modules sub-directory of the blog site as follows, in a new terminal window:

```
$ cd zotonic/priv/sites/blogsite/modules
$ unzip Downloads/zchat-X.zip
$ mv zchat-X mod_chat
```

You need to enable this module from <http://blogsite:8000/admin/modules>. Locate the chat module and activate it. You will need a page and a dispatch rule to access chat.

In the directory `mod_chat/templates`, create a file `chat.tpl` with the following content:

```
{% extends "base.tpl" %}
{% block content %}
    {% include "_chat_box.tpl" %}
{% endblock %}
```

Now create a file `mod_chat/dispatch/dispatch` with the following content:

```
[
    {chat, ["chat"], controller_template, [{template, "chat.
tpl"]}]}
```

```
}
```

From the Zotonic shell, give the command to reload the modules:

```
(zotonic@001@myhost)1> z:m().
```

Browsing <http://blogsite:8000/chat> should display the form for chatting. If you open the same page on another browser, you will see two anonymous users and you can chat between the two browser sessions. You may open the same page on multiple tabs and all the sessions will be part of a group chat.

In case you want to have the option to chat from the home page, you will need to modify `home.tpl` to include `"_chat_box.tpl"`. You can easily include it in the content block. Or if you want to show it in the sidebar, the following lines should be added to `blogsite/template/home.tpl`:

```
{% block sidebar %}
    {% include "_sidebar.tpl" %}
    {% include "_chat_box.tpl" %}
{% endblock %}
```

If you now browse <http://blogspot:8000/>, you should find the chat form in the sidebar. It may not look attractive but it works! Again, you can chat with other users on the home page. However, users on the chat page will not be able to chat with users on the home page. We will return to this a little later.

Usability

Since chatting with anonymous users is not particularly interesting, explore the list of modules and see if the usability can be improved.

The authentication module is already enabled. If you look at the dispatch rules for this module (see file `zotonic/modules/mod_authentication/dispatch/dispatch`), you will find that the two paths needed are `/login` and `/logout`.

You may activate the 'Signup users' module so that the users can create their accounts. The path for this module is `/signup`. Signup requires verification via email, by default. You can disable it by setting `mod_signup.request_confirm` to `false`. You will need to edit the `zotonic/config` file for that.